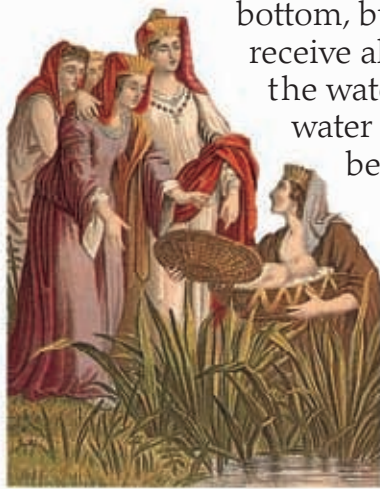


Adapting to water

THE FIRST PLANTS ON EARTH evolved in water. Today, water still teems with microscopic plants that have changed little from those distant ancestors. But aquatic flowering plants have a different history. Their ancestors originally left water and evolved on land, but as time has gone by they have returned to the watery habitat. Only a few flowering plants, such as the eel-grasses, live in the sea. Far more plant species live in ponds, lakes, and rivers. Most of them are rooted to the

bottom, but some have no roots and receive all the nutrients they need from the water instead of the soil. Some water plants are not often noticed, because they spend all their lives under water.

Species like the water lilies are more obvious, because their leaves float on the surface. Plants such as reeds and rushes form a group known as emergent plants. They grow up out of the water and often form thick beds at the water's edge.



HISTORIC HIDEOUT
The Bible tells how the Pharaoh's daughter discovered the infant Moses hidden among bulrushes in the Nile River.

UNDERWATER LEAVES
Fanwort has finely divided underwater leaves, which are not damaged by the current.



Glossy yellow flowers

Greater spearwort

Spear-shaped leaves

LEAVING THE WATER
The greater spearwort is an emergent water plant. It starts its annual cycle of growth under water, but quickly reaches the surface. The flowers bloom about 2 ft (60 cm) above the water, where they attract pollinating insects.



Fanwort